HustLevel Training Guide

How to run the workouts in HustLevel: what the numbers on each exercise mean, how to warm up, when to change the weight, and what to do when something doesn't fit your gym or your week.

This is general training information, not medical advice. If an exercise causes sharp or unusual pain, stop it and swap it for something else.

Your first two weeks

Finding your working weights

Spend the first week or two finding the right weight for every exercise. Treat them as test weeks, not record weeks.

- **You've done the exercise before:** start from the weight in your old logs.
- **The exercise is new:** add a little weight on each warm-up set until you find a weight you can lift for the rep range with 1 to 3 reps left.
- **After that:** log every set. From then on, HustLevel uses your last session to suggest the next weight.

Joining in the middle of a block

You can start the program in any week.

- If your recent training looked similar (similar exercises and a similar number of sets), start in the current week as written.
- If your recent training was different, make your first week an easy week. Do every set, but stop each one with 3 or 4 reps left.

Either way, don't take any set to failure in your first week. New exercises cause the most soreness the first time you do them. An easy first week cuts that soreness a lot, and you lose nothing by it.

Reading a workout

Every exercise in the app shows the same information:

What you see	Example	What it means
Sets × reps	2 × 8-12	Two working sets. Each one should end somewhere between 8 and 12 reps.
Tempo	3-0-1-0	How many seconds each part of a rep takes. See below.
Rest	2-3 min	Rest between sets. The rest timer starts when you tick a set.

What you see	Example	What it means
Notes	"Keep elbows tucked"	Extra instructions for that exercise.

Tempo

Tempo is four numbers, always in this order:

1. **Lowering:** seconds for the part of the rep where the muscle stretches. On a bench press that's the bar coming down. On a pulldown it's the bar going back up.
2. **Pause in the stretch:** seconds to hold at the bottom. 0 means no pause.
3. **Lifting:** seconds for the working part of the rep. 1 means lift with intent, as fast as you can while staying in control.
4. **Pause at the top:** seconds to hold where the muscle is shortest and squeezed.

So 3-0-1-0 on a press means: lower for 3 seconds, no pause, press up in about 1 second, no pause at the top.

Words you'll see

- **Reps in reserve (RIR):** how many more reps you could have done. Stopping with 2 reps left is 2 RIR.
- **Failure:** the point where you can't complete another rep with good form.
- **AMRAP:** as many reps as you can do with good form.
- **Superset:** two exercises back to back. You rest only after the second one.
- **Drop set:** finish the set, take off about a quarter of the weight straight away, and keep going until failure.
- **Eccentric, concentric, isometric:** lowering, lifting, and holding still.
- **Deload:** a lighter week that lets fatigue come down. You use less weight, do fewer sets, or stop further from failure.
- **Progressive overload:** doing a bit more over time. That can be more weight, more reps, or cleaner reps with the same weight.

Warming up

The best warm-up is the exercise itself with less weight. It prepares the exact muscles and joints you're about to use, and it shows you how strong you feel that day.

If you've been sitting all day and feel stiff, start with 5 to 10 minutes of easy walking or cycling. Then do 2 or 3 lighter sets before the first working set for each muscle. None of them should feel hard.

Here's an example for a working weight of 80 kg:

Set	Weight	Reps	Focus
Warm-up 1	40 kg	10	Slow and full range of motion
Warm-up 2	55 kg	5	Same tempo as your working sets
Warm-up 3	70 kg	2	Fast and clean
Working sets	80 kg	8-12	As written in the app

Between warm-up sets, rest only until your breathing settles, usually under a minute. Later exercises for a muscle that's already warm need one warm-up set or none.

Mobility

Lifting through a full range of motion already trains your mobility, so you don't need a separate routine for it. If you like stretching, do it after training or on rest days, not before your working sets.

Making progress

When to change the weight

HustLevel uses double progression. You keep the same weight and add reps until you reach the top of the rep range. Then you add weight, which drops you back toward the bottom of the range, and you build the reps up again.

After each set, check where you landed:

- **At the top of the range, and it felt fine:** add about 5 to 10%, or the smallest jump your gym allows.
- **At the top of the range, but it was a real grind:** keep the weight. Next time, aim to reach the top more comfortably before you go up.
- **Inside the range:** keep the weight and try to beat your reps next time.
- **Below the bottom of the range:** the weight is too heavy. Take a little off so you land inside the range.

The app does this for you. A short tip appears under a set when you go above or below the range, and your next session's weights start heavier or lighter with the reason shown. You can turn the tips off in the Me tab.

How to tell it's working

- **Your logs.** More weight or more reps on the same exercise over several weeks is the clearest sign. Each exercise has a chart in the app, so you can see the trend.
- **Your body.** Scale weight alone can mislead you. Take photos and measure your waist every few weeks. If your weight stays the same while your waist gets smaller and your lifts go up, you're losing fat and building muscle at the same time.

What to expect

How fast you build muscle depends on how long you've been training, your genetics, and how well you train, eat and sleep. Beginners progress fastest. After a year or two, progress slows down, which is normal. Put your attention on the things you control: showing up to every session, good form, enough food and enough sleep.

Swapping an exercise

Sometimes a machine is taken or your gym doesn't have it. A good swap matches the original exercise in three ways:

1. **Same muscle.** A swap for a shoulder exercise should still train the shoulders.
2. **Same movement.** A press for a press, a row for a row, a curl for a curl.
3. **Hardest at the same point.** A cable lateral raise is hard at the bottom of the rep, while a dumbbell lateral raise is almost weightless there. So a cable raise is a closer swap for another cable raise than a dumbbell one is.

Write the swap in the exercise's notes so you use the same one next time and your numbers stay comparable.

The tables below cover the exercises in the built-in program. For anything else, use the three rules above.

Legs

Exercise	Good swaps
Leg Extensions	Cable leg extension with an ankle strap on a low pulley, reverse Nordic
Leg Press (quad or adductor focus)	Hack squat, Smith machine squat with feet slightly forward, heels-elevated goblet squat. Use a wider stance for more inner-thigh work.
Seated Hamstring Curls	Lying leg curl, single-leg cable curl, assisted Nordic curl
Glute Bridge	Barbell or machine hip thrust, cable pull-through, 45-degree back extension with a rounded upper back
Straight Leg Calf Raises	Calf raise on the leg press, Smith machine calf raise, single-leg dumbbell calf raise on a step

Chest and shoulders

Exercise	Good swaps
Converging Flat Press	Flat dumbbell press, flat machine chest press, weighted push-up
Press Deck	Any seated chest press machine, flat dumbbell press

Exercise	Good swaps
Neutral Grip Overhead Press	Seated dumbbell press with palms facing each other, machine shoulder press, landmine press
Machine Lateral Raise	Cable lateral raise, lean-away dumbbell lateral raise, seated dumbbell lateral raise
Mid Range Cable Lateral Raise	Machine lateral raise, cable lateral raise from a lower pulley, lean-away dumbbell lateral raise
Chest Supported Front Raise	Cable front raise, plate front raise

Back

Exercise	Good swaps
Pull Up	Assisted pull-up machine, lat pulldown with the same grip, slow negative pull-ups (jump up, lower for 3 to 5 seconds)
Unilateral Lat Bias Pullaround	Single-arm cable pulldown, single-arm machine pulldown, straight-arm cable pulldown
Seated Lat Bias Row	Single-arm dumbbell row pulling toward your hip, neutral-grip machine row with elbows close to your sides
Upper Back Row	Wide-grip chest-supported T-bar row, seated cable row to the upper chest with elbows out
Kelso Shrug	Lie face down on an incline bench with dumbbells and squeeze your shoulder blades together, or do the same squeeze on a seated cable row with straight arms

Arms and core

Exercise	Good swaps
Kneeling Pushdown	Standing cable pushdown, single-arm cable pushdown, close-grip push-up
Mid Range Cable Curl	Standing dumbbell curl, EZ-bar curl, machine curl
Half Bosu Crunch	Cable crunch, machine crunch, weighted crunch on a stability ball

Recovery and scheduling

Training while sore

Mild soreness is fine. Train as planned. If soreness stops you from moving properly or lifting close to your normal weights, take an extra rest day. One extra day off won't hurt your progress. A forced, sloppy session just adds fatigue.

Never sore at all

You don't need soreness to grow. But if you're never sore and your numbers aren't going up either, you're probably stopping too far from failure. Check how many reps you really have left at the end of your sets.

Missed or moved days

The order of the workouts spreads the work across your muscles so each one gets time to recover. If you miss a day, don't squeeze two workouts together and don't change the order. Do the next workout on your next free day. Your week just shifts by a day.

Equipment

Lifting belt

A belt helps on heavy exercises where you brace your whole torso, like squats and deadlifts. Learn to brace without one first: breathe deep into your belly, tighten your stomach as if someone is about to push you, then lift. You don't need a belt for curls, raises or machine isolation work.

Lifting straps

Use straps when your grip gives out before the muscle you're training. This happens most on heavy rows, pulldowns and Romanian deadlifts. Straps let your back or hamstrings do the work instead of your forearms. If your grip is a weak point, train it separately.

Fat loss or muscle gain

Train the same way whatever your goal is. What you eat decides the result. Eat less than you burn to lose fat, a little more than you burn to gain muscle, or about the same to slowly do both, which works best for beginners. In every case, the training is what tells your body to keep or build muscle.